

**Good morning, everyone. My name is Sergei. Today I would like to tell you a little about myself.**

I am from Belarus. Belarus is a small country in Eastern Europe. It is near Russia, Poland, Lithuania, and Ukraine.

I came to the United States more than five years ago. For my first three years, I lived in Brooklyn, New York. New York was a good place to start because many people there speak Russian, Ukrainian, or Belarusian. When I arrived in the United States, I did not speak English at all.

At first, I thought learning English would be easy. I thought I could start learning it whenever I wanted. But it was much more difficult than I expected. I worked as a waiter and bartender in a Ukrainian restaurant, and most of our customers spoke Russian or Ukrainian. Because of this, I did not use English very much.

Later, I decided to move to Los Angeles. I had only a few friends here, so I had to use English much more.

I started taking free ESL classes at Santa Monica College. I started from the beginning and continued to higher levels. I also study Web Development at SMC. I enjoy programming, and during the last two years, I have worked on different programming projects.

English is very important for my education, but I have another important goal. I want to understand American culture better and become a part of American life. For me, learning English is an important part of this goal.

I like to work on my programming projects by myself. One of my favorite activities in California is hiking. California has many beautiful trails. I can choose easy trails or more difficult ones. In the past, I also played soccer and ran a lot.

I also enjoy meeting people in our class. We have students from many different countries, and I think we can learn a lot from each other.

Learning English is not always easy, but this challenge motivates me to continue learning and improving.

**Thank you very much for listening. If you have any questions, I will be happy to answer them.**